

Student Lesson — Your Professional Presence

Course 18: Professional Presence & Opportunity Building — Lesson 1 of 8

What & Why

Every project you've built, every skill you've practiced, every problem you've solved in Lumexa is worth something beyond the classroom — but only if other people can find it and understand it. That's what a **professional presence** is: the picture of you that exists when someone looks you up online.

Why does this matter now, at 15–18? Because opportunities — mentorships, competitions, internships, scholarships, freelance projects, even your first job — increasingly start with someone searching your name or clicking a link you shared. A strong presence doesn't happen overnight. It's built lesson by lesson, project by project, across this whole course — and it **compounds**: each addition makes the next person's impression of you faster and stronger to form.

This lesson does not assume everyone will use the same tool. It introduces the concept broadly, then splits into two paths so every student — no matter their age — leaves with an equally credible plan.

The LinkedIn Age Rule — Stated Plainly

LinkedIn requires account holders to be at least 16 years old. This is a floor, not a guarantee — some countries or regions require an even higher age, or require a parent/guardian's consent in addition to meeting the age minimum. (This policy can change, so your instructor has verified the current rule before this lesson.)

If you do not meet the applicable age or consent requirement, you do NOT create a LinkedIn account for this class — no exceptions, and no working around the age check. This is not a smaller or lesser path. Instead, you will use the **portfolio-first path**: building a professional "presence page" on the portfolio website you already created in Course 16. It shows the same substance — who you are, what you've built, what you can do — without needing any third-party account at all.

Both paths are treated as fully equal in this course. Your instructor will tell you, or confirm with you, which path applies to you before this lesson.

Two Paths, One Goal

	Path A: LinkedIn-eligible	Path B: Portfolio-first
Who	Students who meet LinkedIn's current age/consent requirement	Students who don't yet meet it, or who prefer not to use LinkedIn

	Path A: LinkedIn-eligible	Path B: Portfolio-first
Where	A LinkedIn profile, kept alongside your portfolio site	A "Presence" page added to your existing Course 16 portfolio site
What it includes	Headline, About, Featured projects, Skills, connections	Headline, About, Project gallery, Skills & Growth, contact method
Owned by	You, but hosted on LinkedIn's platform	You, fully, on your own site
Credibility in this course	Equal	Equal

Worked Example: Two Presences for the Same Fictional Student

Meet **Sam K.**, a fictional Lumexa student, age unspecified — used here purely to show what good content looks like on both paths.

If Sam were on Path A (LinkedIn): - Headline: "Aspiring Software Developer | Python & Web Projects | Lumexa Student" - About: "I'm a student developer who loves building small tools that solve real problems. Currently exploring Python automation and web design." - Featured: link to a Python quiz-game project, link to a personal portfolio site - Skills listed: Python, HTML/CSS, teamwork, problem-solving

If Sam were on Path B (portfolio-first presence page): - Same headline, styled as the page's title - Same About paragraph - A project gallery showing the same two projects — with screenshots and live demo links (something LinkedIn's Featured section can't always show as richly) - A "Skills & Growth" section tracking skills over time - A simple "Contact me" section with an email link — no account required for anyone to reach Sam

Notice: the *content* is almost identical. The only real difference is the venue. That's the point — presence is about substance, not which platform you're on.

Step-by-Step Activity: Which Path Applies to You?

1. Confirm with your instructor which path applies to you (Path A or Path B) — this has already been determined before class based on age/consent information on file.
2. If you're Path A: note that you'll set up your LinkedIn profile in a later lesson, once your account eligibility is confirmed by you and your family.
3. If you're Path B: open your Course 16 portfolio site and locate (or plan) where a new "Presence" page will live.
4. Either way, open Worksheet.md and complete **Part 1: Eligibility Self-Check** now.
5. Move to **Part 2: Reflection** and **Part 3: Goals for the Course** — these apply to every student regardless of path.

Key Terms

- **Professional presence** — the full, discoverable picture of your skills, projects, and reliability that exists online, across whatever platforms and pages you use.
- **Reputation** — the pattern of trust and credibility that builds up over time from consistent, honest, quality presence — it compounds rather than resets each time.
- **Discoverability** — how easily someone can find accurate, relevant information about you when they search or click through from something you shared.
- **Portfolio-first** — the approach of building your professional presence entirely on a site you own (your Course 16 portfolio), rather than on a third-party platform account.

Knowledge Checks

1. What is the minimum age LinkedIn currently requires for an account, and what else might raise that requirement?
2. True or False: A professional presence is the same thing as having one social media profile.
3. Name two things a portfolio-first presence page includes that a LinkedIn profile also includes.
4. If a student doesn't meet the LinkedIn age/consent requirement, what should they do instead?
5. Why does professional presence "compound" over time rather than being a one-time task?

Reflection Prompts

1. If someone searched your name right now, what would they actually find — and is it a fair picture of you?
2. Which of your existing Lumexa projects would you most want a stranger to see first, and why?
3. What is one thing you want your professional presence to communicate about you by the end of this course?

Submission Instructions

Complete all three parts of Worksheet.md (Eligibility Self-Check, Reflection, Goals for the Course) and submit it through your Lumexa class dashboard before Lesson 2. If you're on Path B, also come to Lesson 2 with access to edit your Course 16 portfolio site.